

INSIDE A FLOWER



Hibiscus

When you look at flowers you notice many colors, shapes, and sizes. Some plants have a single flower, others have so many it is impossible to keep count. But stop and take a closer look—this time inside. However different they may look, flowers all have the same basic parts. This is because all plants produce flowers for the same purpose: to make seeds so another plant can grow.



Mistaken identity

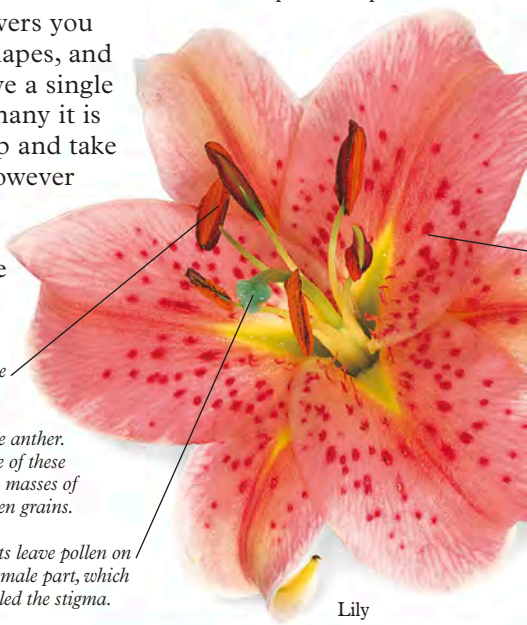
You could be confused by this poinsettia. What look like bright red petals are actually a kind of leaf, called a bract. The real flowers are the tiny green dots in the center.

The male part of a flower is called the anther. Each one of these produces masses of tiny pollen grains.

Insects leave pollen on the female part, which is called the stigma.

New beginnings

The process of making new seeds is called reproduction. The male and female parts in the center of this lily are its reproductive parts.



Lily

Grand finale

Not all plants flower every year, but there is no other plant that is as slow as the *Puya raimondii* from South America. It takes 150 years to produce a massive flower spike, up to 33 feet (10 meters) tall. Exhausted, it then dies, but luckily, not before it has produced a few seeds.

